THE BATTLE OF THE NILE

FRENCH REVOLUTIONARY WARS



THE BATTLE OF THE NILE

Date	August 1–2, 1798
Location	Near Alexandria, Egypt
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	FRANCE

COMMANDERS

Horatio Nelson	François-Paul Brueys

FORCES

Ships: 14 ships of the line	**Ships:** 13 ships of the line, 4 frigates

LOSSES

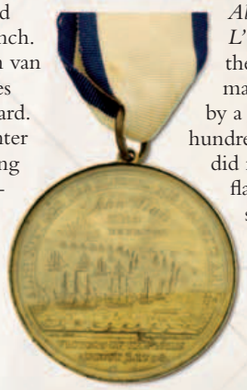
Men: 800 **Ships:** none	**Men:** 2,000–5,000 **Ships:** 11 ships of the line, 2 frigates

On May 19, 1798, General Napoleon Bonaparte set sail from Toulon for Egypt, his army transports escorted by 13 ships of the line and four frigates commanded by Admiral François-Paul Brueys. Bonaparte was fortunate to avoid interception by a Royal Navy force under Admiral Horatio Nelson, which was vainly criss-crossing the Mediterranean in search of the French convoy. Bonaparte landed his army in Aboukir Bay at the start of July, and it was there, a month later, that Nelson at last came upon Brueys.

Nelson found the French ships anchored in line in the sandy bay with their port side to the shore. Although it was dusk he signaled an immediate attack. His captains were ordered to concentrate on the French van and center; because of the wind direction, the ships at the French rear would find it impossible to join the fight and could be rolled up later. The British ships, all 74s except the 50-gun *Leander*, entered the bay with *Goliath* leading. Probably on his own initiative, Captain Thomas Foley took *Goliath* around the head of the French line and into the shallow inshore water; four others followed him. This was a maneuver for which the French were wholly unprepared. The gun ports on their landward sides were closed and the decks uncleared.

As darkness fell a savage fight was joined. Thirteen British ships (one, *Culloden*, having run aground on a reef) anchored to hold position alongside the French. The five 74s of the French van were battered by broadsides from both port and starboard. The larger ships in the center of the French line, including Brueys's three-decker 120-gun flagship *L'Orient*, at first fared better. The *Bellerophon* took terrible punishment from the flagship's guns, drifting dismasted out of the fighting.

The horrors and heroism of that night were to become legendary. The captain of *Le Tonnant*, Dupetit-Thouars, with one arm and both legs shot away, had himself propped up in a barrel of bran to continue the fight. *Le Guerrier*, first in the French line, went on fighting with only one gun left firing, until the British sent a boat across to the shattered ship to persuade her captain to strike. Nelson, aboard his flagship *Vanguard*, had his forehead cut open by grapeshot and, temporarily blinded, thought he was dying. The climactic moment came at around 10 p.m.



Nile victory medal
Dedicated to John Lewes of HMS *Defence*, this medal shows the British fleet going into action and the French fleet at anchor.

Battered by broadsides from *Alexander* and *Swiftsure*, *L'Orient* caught fire. When the flame spread to her magazine, she was destroyed by a gigantic explosion. The hundred survivors from *L'Orient* did not include Brueys or his flag captain Casabianca, whose son, refusing to leave the doomed ship, would later be immortalized in verse as "the boy who stood on the burning deck."

The ships in the rear of the French line, under Villeneuve, were impotent spectators of this immense carnage. When the sun rose on a bay floating with dead bodies and wreckage, the futility of continuing resistance by the French was apparent. Villeneuve seized a chance to slip away, thereby saving two ships of the line and a couple of frigates, only to face unfair accusations of cowardice that he would seek to efface seven years later at the battle of Trafalgar. Nelson's phenomenal victory (nine French ships of the line taken, two destroyed) made him a national hero.

> "THE WHOLE BAY WAS COVERED WITH DEAD BODIES, MANGLED, WOUNDED, AND SCORCHED, NOT A BIT OF CLOTHES ON THEM EXCEPT THEIR TROUSERS."
>
> **JOHN NICOL**, A SAILOR ABOARD HMS *GOLIATH*

The start of the action
The French fleet lies at anchor in Aboukir Bay at 6:30 p.m. The British fleet sails into position from right to left, *Goliath* rounding the head of the French line. Four French frigates lie to the left, with Aboukir Fort in the background.